

TSA Complaint Trends Before, During, and After COVID-19

Analysis of TSA Complaint Patterns Using Public Transportation Complaint Data



Teresa Ferrill

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Project Overview

- TSA complaint data was analyzed to identify long-term trends
- The project examined how complaint volume changed over time
- Additional analysis looked at:
 - Complaint categories
 - Airport Trends
 - Geographic patterns
 - Temporal changes during COVID-19

1,020,992

Total Complaints

444

Airports Included

2015 - 2024

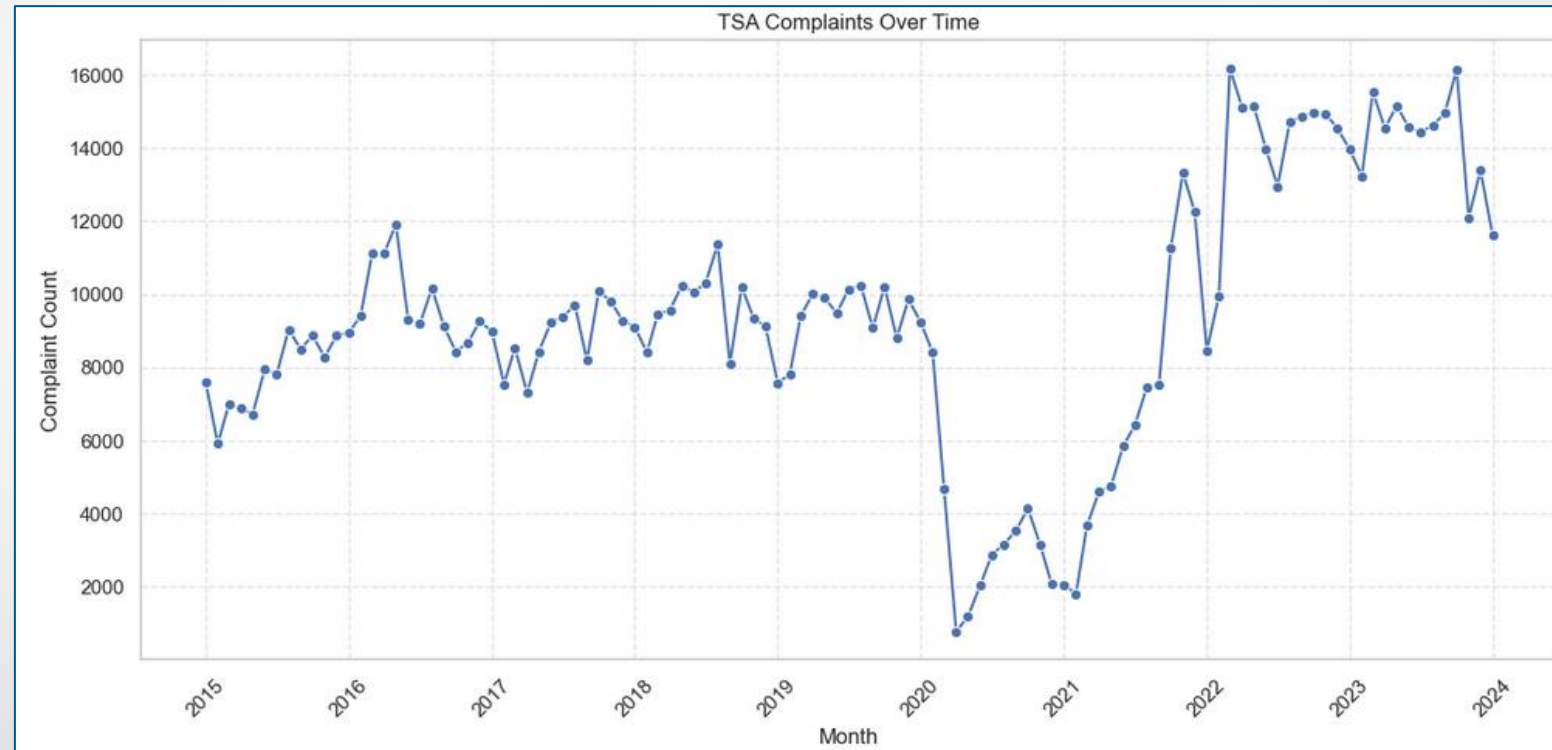
Years Analyzed

Key
Performance
Indicators
from Datasets



Impact of COVID-19 on Complaint Volume

- Before 2020
 - Stable complaint activity
- COVID Decline
 - Sharp decline during pandemic
- Recovery Period
 - Complaints rebounded with travel recovery

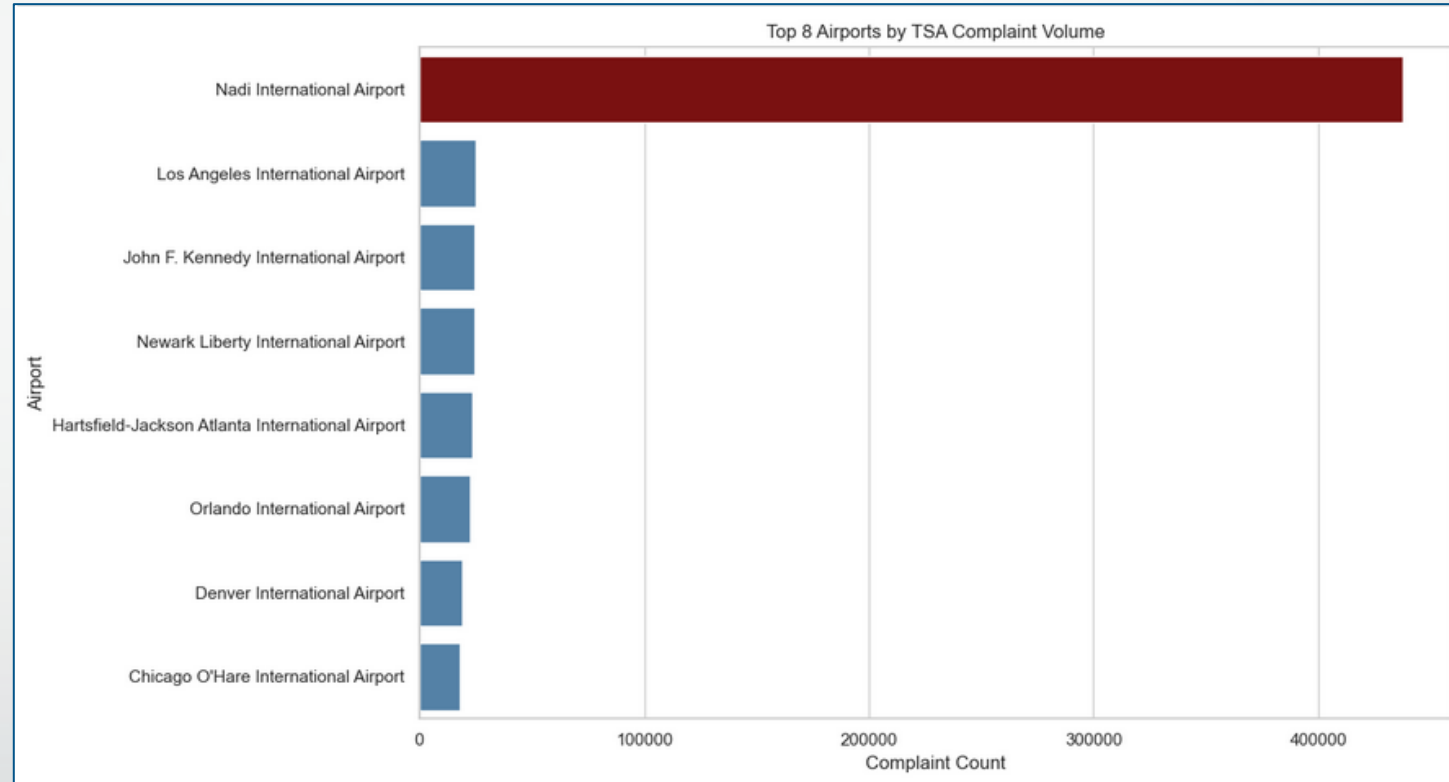


Complaint activity closely followed changes in national travel behavior during the pandemic



Top Airports by Complaint Volume

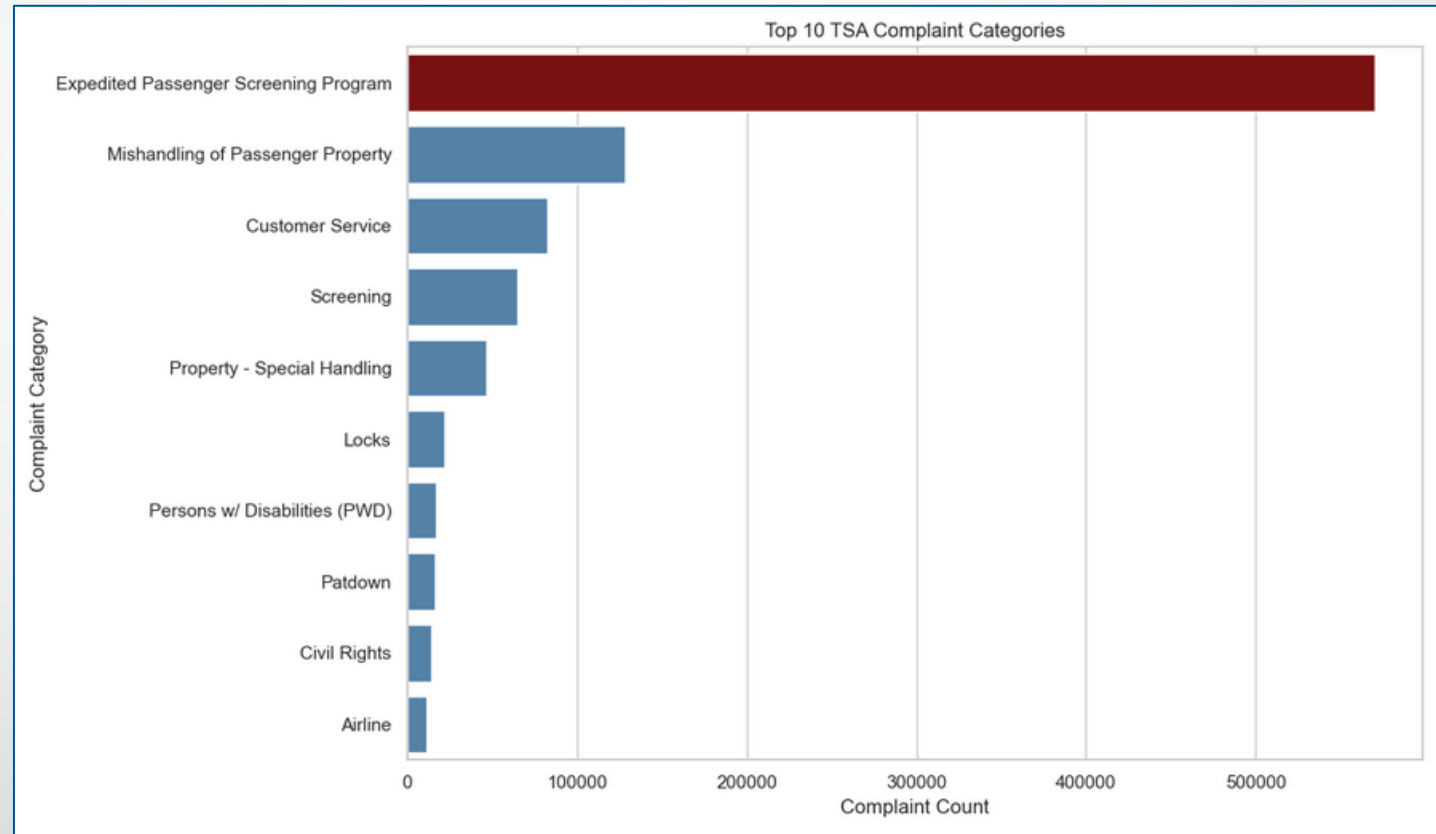
- Larger airports naturally produce more complaints due to traffic volume
- Complaint concentration is uneven across airports
- Major hubs dominate the rankings





Complaint Categories

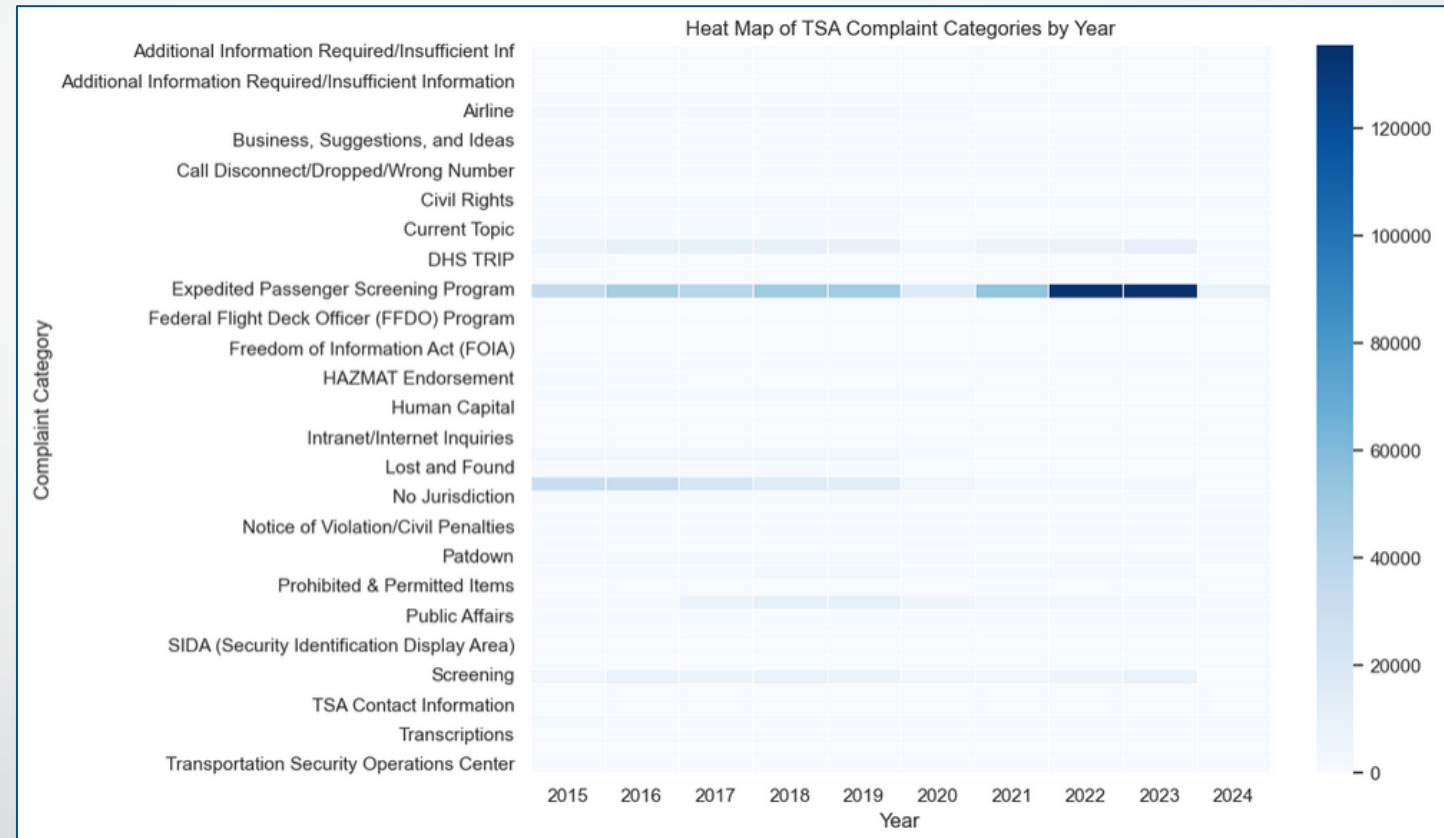
- Some complaint categories consistently appear more frequently
- Operational disruptions and customer service issues often dominate
- Patterns may reflect passenger stress during heavy travel periods





Heat Map by Year

- Certain complaint types intensified during recovery years
- The heat map helps identify periods of concentrated complaint activity

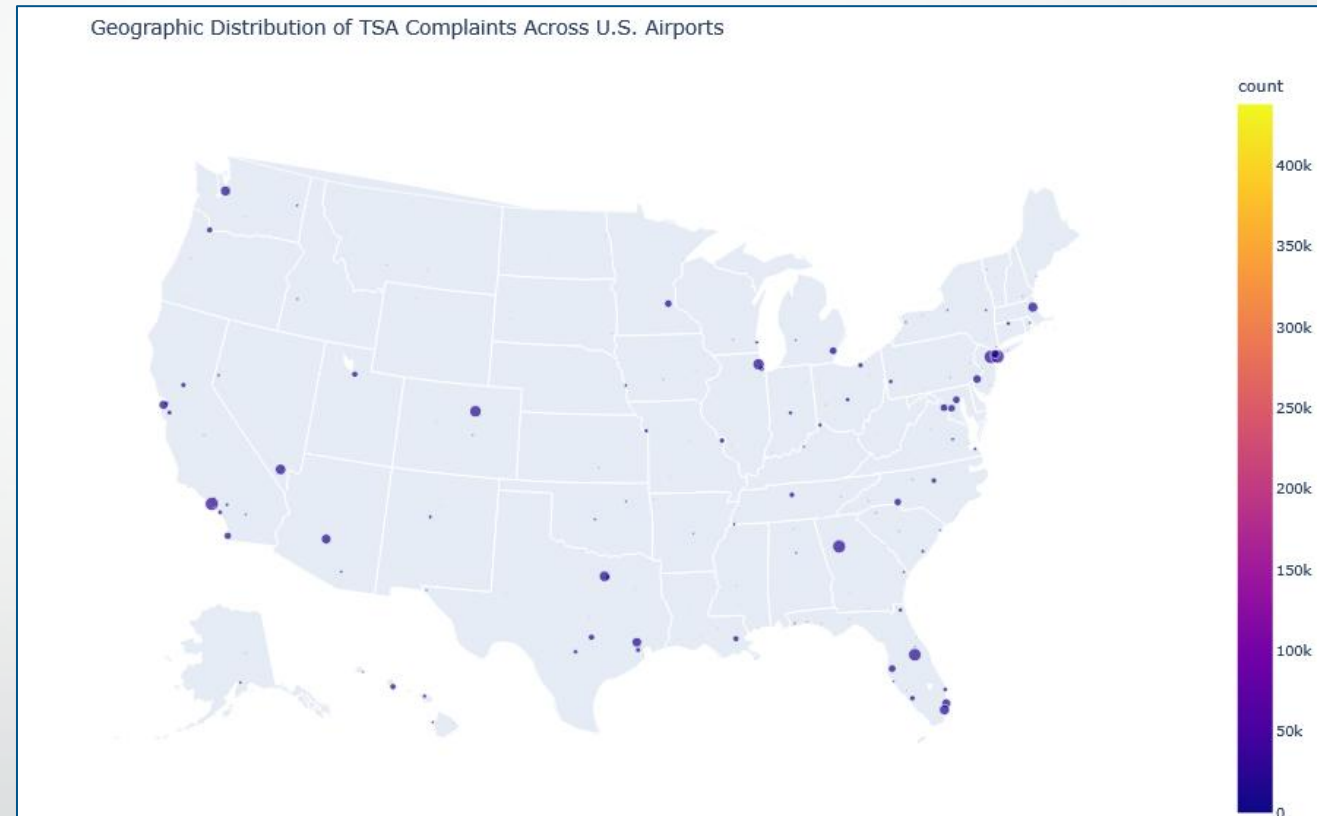




Geographic Distribution Across the U.S.

- Complaint activity is concentrated around major travel corridors

Airport Name	Airport Code	Complaint Count
Nadi International Airport	NAN	437786
Los Angeles International Airport	LAX	24794
John F. Kennedy International Airport	JFK	24677
Newark Liberty International Airport	EWK	24405
Hartsfield-Jackson Atlanta International Airport	ATL	23591
Orlando International Airport	MCO	22308
Denver International Airport	DEN	19015
Chicago O'Hare International Airport	ORD	18256
Dallas/Fort Worth International Airport	DFW	15954
Harry Reid International Airport	LAS	15937

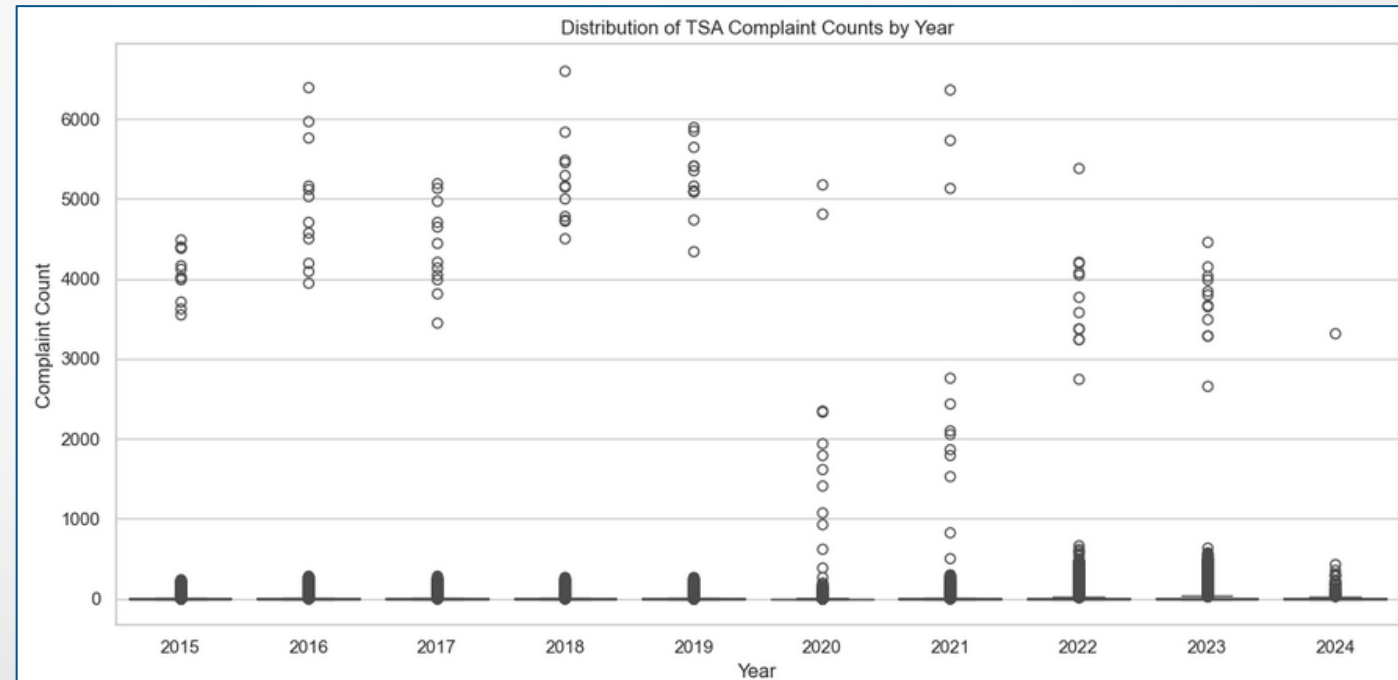


Geographic clustering reflects passenger density and airport traffic



TSA Complaint Distribution by Airport

- Most airports had lower complaint levels
- Several airports appeared as significant outliers
- Complaint activity was not evenly distributed
- Major hubs likely drove higher complaint counts



Complaint activity varies significantly across airports – several locations report higher complaint volumes over the national average



Key Findings, Summary

- Complaint volume dropped significantly during COVID-19
- Complaint activity increased again as travel recovered
- Major airport hubs generated the largest complaint totals
- Complaint categories were not evenly distributed
- Geographic patterns aligned with high-volume travel regions

Geographic clustering reflects passenger density and airport traffic



Limitations

- Complaint counts do not necessarily measure airport quality
- Passenger traffic volume differs across airports
- Reporting behavior may vary over time
- Dataset may not capture all traveler experiences

COVID-era travel restrictions significantly influenced results



Conclusion

- The analysis demonstrates how external events such as COVID-19 can dramatically influence transportation complaint patterns.
- The results also show that complaint activity is closely connected to passenger travel behavior, airport traffic volume, and operational disruptions within the airline industry.
- **Call to Action:** TSA leadership should prioritize operational reviews at the highest-volume complaint airports and focus improvement efforts on the most frequent complaint categories to reduce recurring traveler issues.



References

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- Transportation Security Administration. (2024). TSA complaint datasets. Retrieved from <https://github.com/tsa-complaint-counts>
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